

The LinkedIn Visibility Playbook for Jobseekers

How to be found in LinkedIn Recruiter — the paid database recruiters actually search, which is not the LinkedIn you use.

8 phases

One-time setup, then 30 min a week

Every claim sourced

What makes this different. Every mechanism claim here is checked against LinkedIn's own documentation and published research. Where the market asserts something LinkedIn has never published, this playbook says so and tells you what to do anyway. Entry IDs like [KB-005](#) point to the public knowledge base behind each call.

INSIDE

- 01 Why you are invisible — and the two models everyone confuses
 - 02 The five Spotlights, and the one move that enters each
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Why you are invisible

Recruiters do not browse LinkedIn. They query a paid database — **LinkedIn Recruiter** — using title filters, skills filters, location filters and Boolean strings, then work down a ranked list. **If you are not in the result set for the searches that match your target role, you do not exist to the people hiring for it.** There is no rejection email for a search you were never in.

Q “Marketing Director” OR “Head of Marketing” AND Singapore

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results, for a candidate who is qualified.

A wrong title field, an unlisted skill, or the wrong industry setting removes you from the set before ranking is even considered. **You are not being rejected. You are not being retrieved.**

Recruiter search matches against **structured profile fields**: job titles (filterable by Current, Past, or Current-or-Past), skills, location, industry, companies, schools and spoken languages — each with Must-have / Can-have / Doesn't-have logic. On top of the ranked list sit **Spotlights**, priority segments recruiters use to narrow to candidates most likely to engage.

THE 2026 UPDATE. STATED PRECISELY

LinkedIn's current recruiter-side stack runs **two separate models**, and almost every guide on the internet collapses them into one.

Retrieval decides whether you are in the result set at all. It matches on meaning, not keyword frequency — so repeating your target title five times does not help you.

Ranking decides the order of that set, and it is a different model trained on different signals.

What follows: comprehensive coverage of the skills, contexts and outcomes of your target role is what gets you *into* the set, and being in the set is the whole game. **Nothing on your profile is a published ranking lever.** Anyone who tells you otherwise is describing a system LinkedIn has not documented. [KB-001](#) [KB-002](#)

Five filters, five behaviours you control

Spotlights sit at the top of every Recruiter search and segment candidates by likelihood to engage. Each one is a switch, not a score.

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- 01** **Open to Work** — candidates who switched the signal on. Set it to “Recruiters only” and it stays out of your network's ordinary view while making you filterable.
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- 02** **Active Talent / more likely to respond** — recently updated the profile, shared a resume with recruiters, answers InMails, longer-than-average tenure in role, or works somewhere with recent layoffs.
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- 03** **Company Connections** — 1st-degree connections of employees at the recruiter's own organisation. One accepted connection puts you in this segment for every recruiter there.
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- 04** **Engaged with Talent Brand** — clicked “I'm interested” on a company page, follows the page, or liked / shared / commented on its posts, job posts or sponsored content.
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- 05** **Past Applicants** — previously applied, or started applying, to a role at the company.
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Open to Work → switch it to Recruiters-only today, with every target title listed

Active Talent → edit one line of your profile every week, and answer every InMail

Company Connections → connect with any five employees at a target company

Engaged with Talent Brand → follow the company page and comment on one post

Past Applicants → you are already in it if you have ever applied there

Read them as filters, not boosts. A Spotlight does not move you up a list. It decides which list you are on. That distinction is the single most useful thing on this page.

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Reverse-engineer the search

One-time · 30 minutes

- Write the 2–3 search strings a recruiter would actually type for your target role: exact titles + location, e.g. `("Marketing Director" OR "Head of Marketing") AND Singapore`.
- Harvest **5 live job descriptions per target title**. Extract the 15–20 recurring skill and function nouns. This is your keyword map — write in the market's language, not your employer's internal one.

1

Profile field engineering

One-time · 60 minutes

- **Current job title field.** The highest-stakes field on your profile, because recruiters filter on Current title. Use the market-standard title for what you do. The field accepts pipes for a hybrid — `Fractional CMO | Marketing & Communications Director`. A creative or internal title makes you unfilterable, which is worse than being ranked low.
- **Past titles.** Align every past role to its recognisable market-standard title. Past-title is also a filter.
- **Headline.** Target titles + specialisms + region + languages. It appears in every search result and every message you send. Keywords, not slogans.
- **About.** Front-load the first two lines — they show in previews — with target titles, years, and region. Then cover, naturally and once or twice each, the skills, tools, contexts and outcomes from your keyword map. **Coverage beats repetition.**
- **Experience bullets.** The exact terms recruiters search for should appear here, tied to outcomes.
- **Location and industry.** Both are hard filters. The wrong industry silently excludes you from filtered searches and you will never know.

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Skills – the under-used lever

One-time, then quarterly

- Recruiter has a dedicated Skills filter with **exact matching** against LinkedIn's standardised skill names. **Salesforce** and **Salesforce CRM** are different skills. Add the exact variant that appears in the job descriptions you harvested.
- List **15–25 genuinely relevant skills**, and pin your top 3 to match your target titles. **Pinned skills are the ones shown first on your profile** — a human-readability gain. Whether pinning affects filtering is unpublished.
- Get endorsements on your top 10. **Mechanism unpublished:** LinkedIn has never stated that endorsement count affects skill-filtered results. What is certain is that a skill must be listed to be filterable at all. Treat endorsements as a cheap tiebreaker you cannot verify, not a lever.
- Tag skills to specific roles, projects and education. This is LinkedIn's current mechanism for evidencing skills. It replaced Skill Assessments, **discontinued in 2023 with badges removed in 2024** — ignore any guide still recommending them.

3

Recruiter-facing signals

15 minutes

- **Open to Work, "Recruiters only"**. Add all target titles, locations and start date. **This is a literal Recruiter filter — a checkbox at the top of the search, not a ranking boost.** Recruiters use it because it narrows a list to people who have said they are open. That is the entire mechanism, and it is enough reason to switch it on. **KB-005**
- **Answer every InMail within 24 hours**, including polite declines. Responsiveness feeds the "more likely to respond" segment; ignored InMails push you out of it.
- **Follow target companies**, click "I'm interested" where offered, engage with their posts, set job alerts. Each action feeds Engaged with Talent Brand.
- **Make a small profile update weekly.** A recent profile update is an explicit Active Talent signal.

The caveat that goes with Open to Work, every time. "Recruiters only" is best-effort, not guaranteed. LinkedIn's own wording is that it *takes steps to prevent* Recruiter users at your current company from seeing it, but *cannot guarantee complete privacy*. The exclusion is **company-based** — it does not cover agency recruiters, RPOs or contractors working for your employer. If your employer uses an agency, assume they can see it. **KB-005**

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Activity engine

Daily floor

- **Floor: 3 substantive comments a day** in your target function, and 2–3 posts a week.
 - Make post opening lines keyword-rich. Posts are a searchable surface, and the first line frames the topic for both people and retrieval.
 - **Comment on posts by recruiters and hiring managers at target organisations.** Your name in their notifications precedes your name in their search results.
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What activity does and does not do. Recency and activity are widely asserted as *ranking* factors and are **not published as such**. What is documented: a recent profile update feeds the Active Talent spotlight, which is a filter recruiters switch on. That is a real, checkable reason to stay active — and it does not require the ranking claim. [KB-013](#)

5

Graph engineering

Weekly

- **Connect with 5 employees per target company per week** — any function, not just HR. One accepted connection puts you in the Company Connections spotlight for every recruiter at that organisation, and moves you from 3rd- to 2nd-degree in their searches.
- **Connect with 5 TA professionals a week** in your market. Closer-degree candidates are easier for recruiters to reach and to see activity from.
- Join the 3–4 groups where your function's recruiters congregate. Shared groups extend reach and discoverability.

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Off-LinkedIn reinforcement

Monthly

- **Recruiters Google shortlisted candidates.** Own page one of your name: LinkedIn profile, one bylined article or podcast appearance, a personal or practice site.
- Mirror your headline keywords on every other platform recruiters and sourcing tools crawl — regional job boards, professional directories.
- Publish one anchor article a month under your name on your specialism. Authority content is increasingly retrieved by the AI search tools recruiters and hiring managers now use.

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The weekly measurement loop

Friday · 30 minutes

Do not use a logged-out browser search as your measure. It queries LinkedIn's *public* search, not LinkedIn Recruiter — a different index, a different ranking, a different result set. It tells you nothing about the database recruiters pay for. Measuring the wrong surface is the most common error in this entire market, and it is the one that makes people give up on work that was actually succeeding.

Use LinkedIn's own numbers about the right surface instead:

- **Search appearances** (profile analytics). How many searches surfaced you this week, and which keywords did it. The closest published measure of findability you have access to.
- **Who viewed your profile**, filtered for recruiter and TA titles. Rising recruiter views means the loop is working. Flat views means revisit the Current title field, then skills, then the activity floor — in that order.
- **Close the gap.** Compare the keywords that surfaced you against your target keyword map, then rotate one keyword from that week's JD harvest into your headline or About. The edit doubles as an Active Talent signal.

Five moves, in this order

- 01 Fix the **Current job title** field to a market-standard, filterable title.

- 02 Switch on **Open to Work (Recruiters only)** with all target titles and locations.

- 03 Load and pin **skills that exact-match** the terms in your target job descriptions.

- 04 Connect with **employees at target companies** — the fastest spotlight to enter.

- 05 Hold the **activity floor**: 3 comments a day, 2–3 posts a week, one small profile update weekly.

Number one is not a preference. Every other move on this list operates *inside* a result set that the title field decides you are in.

Four things you have been told that are wrong

Checked against LinkedIn's own documentation and published research. This is what the rest of the market is still repeating.

"Take LinkedIn Skill Assessments for the badges"

Outdated. Assessments were discontinued in 2023 and badges removed in 2024. Tag skills to roles and projects instead.

"Repeat your keyword three to five times"

Outdated. Retrieval matches on meaning. Semantic coverage of skills, contexts and outcomes beats keyword frequency, and stuffing is now visible as stuffing. [KB-001](#)

"Only bother connecting with recruiters"

Incomplete. The Company Connections spotlight keys on 1st-degree connections with *any* employee of the hiring organisation. The finance manager counts.

"Open to Work looks desperate"

Wrong for the Recruiters-only setting — it is a search filter, and it is hidden from your network's ordinary view of your profile. But LinkedIn does not guarantee that, and the exclusion does not cover agencies working for your employer. Switch it on with your eyes open. [KB-005](#)

And one we will not tell you. You will find confident percentages for how much better Open to Work candidates respond. That quantity currently circulates in **three incompatible sizes, two of them citing LinkedIn**. We do not repeat any of them. The mechanism is the point, and the mechanism does not need a number. [KB-005](#)

Where every claim came from

Primary sources: LinkedIn Help — *Spotlights in Recruiter and Jobs; Filter search results in Recruiter and Recruiter Lite; Skill Assessments* — *no longer available*. LinkedIn's published research on candidate retrieval and ranking. Supplemented by current sourcing-practice analysis, 2025–2026.

Where this playbook says **mechanism unpublished**, it means exactly that: the practice is worth doing for a reason we can state, and the ranking claim attached to it in the market has no primary source. We would rather tell you that than sell you a certainty.

DO ONE THING THIS WEEK

Run the search a recruiter would run for your role. If you are not in it, you now know exactly which field to fix first.

Want it checked for you — thefindablecandidate.com/check

The 20-point findability checklist — thefindablecandidate.com/checklist

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